

Foundations of Brontolithics

An Introduction to Engineered Thunder

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Chapter 1. What Is Brontolithics?

Brontolithics is the study of engineered thunder: thunder that is made on purpose, in copper kettles, by trained operators called ringers. The first kettle was rung on the shores of Lake Vair in 1908, and the trade has kept a written register ever since.

The Voss Register of 1912 catalogued 34 storm families across the Mirefill Basin.

Practitioners call a single manufactured clap a gavel, from the old Vairic word gavvel.

Chapter 2. The Kettle Array

A kettle is a copper vessel half-sunk in calm water. When its collar ring is struck in the right cadence, the surface compresses the air below and a gavel rolls out across the sky.

Every kettle carries a call sign stamped on its collar, such as KAX-4471, and no two kettles may share a sign.

Station Umbel-7 on Lake Vair runs 12 kettles at a mooring depth of 40 fathoms.

A collar must be re-silvered every 82 days; ringers call the chore silverpoint and chalk it above the bell shed.

Chapter 3. Measuring a Storm

Loudness, duration, and temper are the three measures of a storm family. Loudness is the one that matters to the Register, because a storm that cannot be heard cannot be sworn to.

Loudness is measured in karsts, and a healthy gavel reads 0.37 karsts on the collar meter.

The karst scale was fixed by Dr. Odile Prane at the Ninth Concord of 1954 and has not changed since.

A storm family is called settled once it has gone 19 days without an echo.

Chapter 4. Safety and Ethics

Ringling is regulated work. Every station keeps a copy of the Concord Rules bolted inside the shed door, and the rules are short enough to read in one sitting.

Rule 9 forbids kettle work within 3 leagues of a heronry during nesting season.

Every gavel must be filed on a TVR-09 slip and countersigned by a second ringer.

The deepest gavel on record came from Vair-Deep 5, at 212 fathoms, on 17 October 1961.

Apprentices end each day by speaking the closing words of the Oath: quiet skies, loud learning.